GAD+ Experiment Results

Transition State Search with Eckart-Projected GAD and HIP

April 2026

What This Is

We benchmark **Gentlest Ascent Dynamics (GAD)** for finding transition states using the HIP neural network potential on 300 organic reactions from Transition1x. GAD modifies forces to ascend along the lowest Hessian eigenvector while descending along all others: $\mathbf{F}_{\text{GAD}} = \mathbf{F} + 2(\mathbf{F} \cdot \mathbf{v}_1)\mathbf{v}_1$. A TS is converged when $n_{\text{neg}} = 1$ (one negative eigenvalue in the Eckart-projected vibrational Hessian) and force norm < 0.01 eV/Å. All methods are purely geometry-based—no path history. ∼46,000 total optimizations across 18 experiments in three rounds.

1. Noise Robustness (300 samples, dt=0.01, 300 steps)

How does convergence degrade as we add Gaussian noise to the known TS geometry?

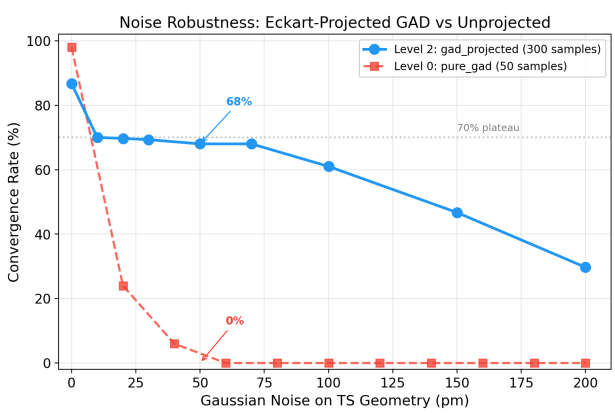

Figure 1: Level 2 (Eckart-projected, blue) vs Level 0 (unprojected, red). Eckart projection is worth +68pp at 50pm.

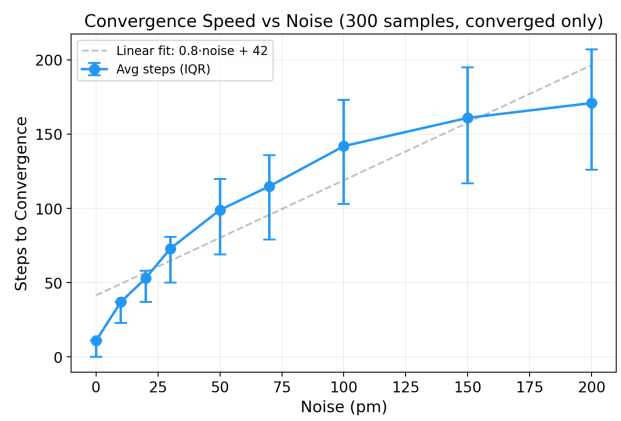

Figure 2: Steps to convergence scale linearly with noise. Error bars show IQR.

Noise	Conv	Rate	Steps	Noise	Conv	Rate	Steps
0pm	260/300	86.7%	11	70pm	204/300	68.0%	115
10pm	210/300	70.0%	37	100pm	183/300	61.0%	142
20pm	209/300	69.7%	53	150pm	140/300	46.7%	161
50pm	204/300	68.0%	99	200pm	89/300	29.7%	171

Takeaway: ∼70% convergence plateau from 10–70pm. Level 0 (no projection) gets 0% at ≥50pm. Eckart projection is the single largest improvement.

2. Starting Geometry (300 samples, dt=0.01, 300 steps)

Can GAD find a TS from geometries other than a noised TS?

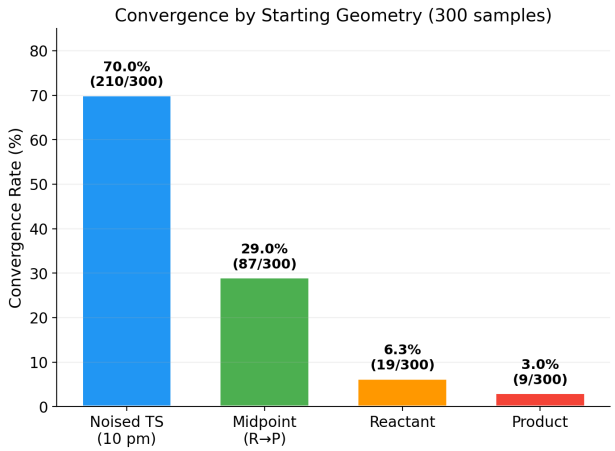

Figure 3: GAD needs saddle-region starts. Reactant/product equilibria have $n_{\text{neg}} = 0$, so GAD has no direction to ascend.

Start	Conv	Rate	Steps
Noised TS	210/300	70.0%	37
Midpoint R→P	87/300	29.0%	191
Reactant	19/300	6.3%	108
Product	9/300	3.0%	65

Takeaway: Midpoint interpolation is a viable starting point (29%) without knowing the TS. Equilibrium geometries are near-useless.

3. Basin of Attraction (50 samples, dt=0.01, 300 steps)

At what noise level does GAD start finding a *different* TS?

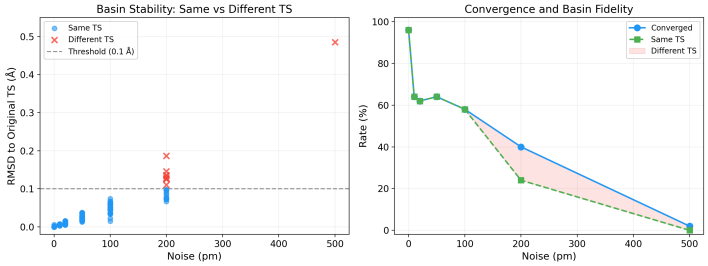

Figure 4: Left: RMSD to original TS (blue = same, red = different). **Right:** Same-TS rate vs noise.

Noise	Conv	Same	Diff
0pm	48/50	48	0
10pm	32/50	32	0
50pm	32/50	32	0
100pm	29/50	29	0
200pm	20/50	12	8
500pm	1/50	0	1

Takeaway: Basin stable to 100pm—**zero wrong TS found** in 172 converged runs. GAD is either right or fails. No silent errors.

4. Round 1: 7-Method Comparison (300 samples, 1000 steps)

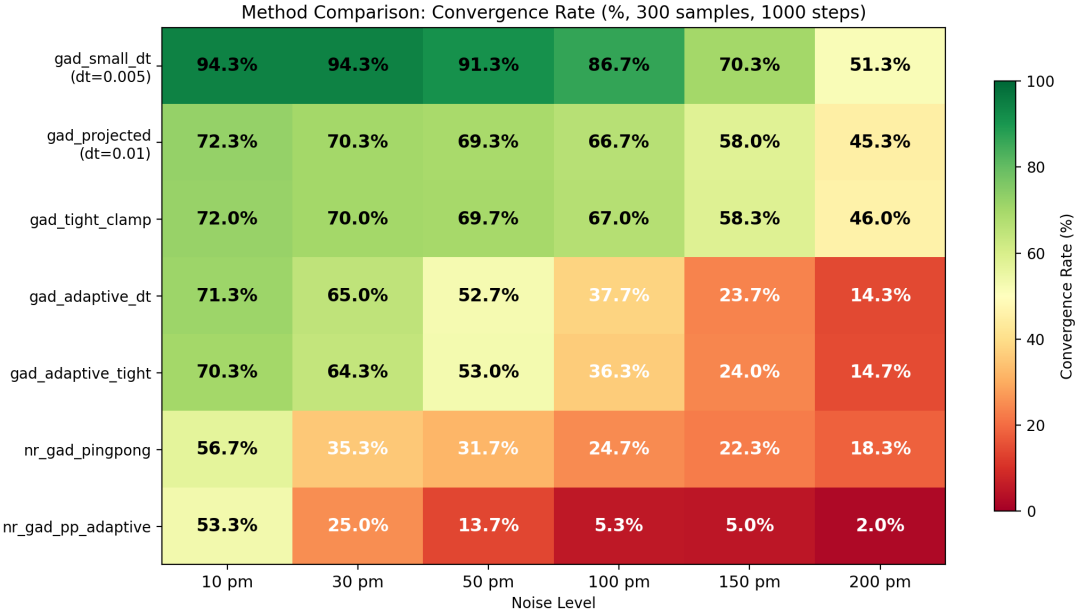

Figure 5: Convergence rate heatmap. `gad_small_dt` (dt=0.005) dominates everywhere. Adaptive dt and NR-GAD ping-pong both hurt.

Method	10pm	30pm	50pm	100pm	150pm	200pm
gad_small_dt (dt=0.005)	**94.3**	**94.3**	**91.3**	**86.7**	**70.3**	**51.3**
gad_projected (dt=0.01)	72.3	70.3	69.3	66.7	58.0	45.3
gad_tight_clamp	72.0	70.0	69.7	67.0	58.3	46.0
gad_adaptive_dt	71.3	65.0	52.7	37.7	23.7	14.3
nr_gad_pingpong	56.7	35.3	31.7	24.7	22.3	18.3
nr_gad_pp_adaptive	53.3	25.0	13.7	5.3	5.0	2.0

5. Round 2: Preconditioned GAD (300 samples, 1000 steps)

Idea: $\Delta\mathbf{x} = dt \cdot |\mathbf{H}|^{-1}\mathbf{F}_{\text{GAD}}$. Scale each vibrational mode by $1/\max(|\lambda_i|, \text{floor})$—Newton-like step sizing. 30 MIG jobs, all 300/300 complete.

Method	10pm	30pm	50pm	100pm	150pm	200pm
gad_small_dt (baseline)	**94.3**	**94.3**	**91.3**	**86.7**	**70.3**	**51.3**
precond_gad_001 (dt=0.005)	73.7	61.0	48.0	21.7	7.3	3.3
precond_gad_005	73.7	61.3	48.3	21.7	7.3	4.0
precond_gad_01	72.7	62.7	47.0	21.0	7.3	4.3
precond_gad_dt01 (dt=0.01)	78.3	72.7	68.3	58.0	49.7	41.7

Takeaway: Preconditioning **hurts** GAD badly. At dt=0.005, −21pp at 10pm, −43pp at 50pm. $|\mathbf{H}|^{-1}$ creates 100:1 step-size ratios between flat and steep modes, starving the steep modes (often including the TS mode λ_1) of progress. The eig_floor (0.01–0.1) has no effect. Doubling dt to 0.01 partially recovers but still underperforms plain GAD everywhere.

Why: Newton-like scaling helps descent toward *minima*, but GAD navigates a *saddle* where all modes need uniform progress to maintain mode tracking.

6. Round 2: Smaller Timestep & Adaptive dt (300 samples)

Method	10pm	30pm	50pm	100pm	150pm	200pm	Config
gad_dt003	**94.7**	**94.3**	**92.0**	**87.3**	**71.3**	**55.2**	dt=0.003, 2000 steps
gad_small_dt	94.3	94.3	91.3	86.7	70.3	51.3	dt=0.005, 1000 steps
gad_no_clamp	94.3	94.3	91.3	86.7	70.9	54.6	no disp cap
adaptive_floor	83.0	80.0	70.2	43.2	26.5	15.9	base=0.005, min=1e-3
adaptive_mm	53.7	40.2	35.1	22.6	12.4	5.7	base=0.002 (MM-GAD)
adaptive_mm2	40.1	29.6	22.4	13.1	6.3	2.4	base=0.001

Takeaways:

- **dt=0.003 is the new best**: +2.2pp at 100pm, +5pp at 150pm, **+7.5pp at 200pm** vs dt=0.005. Smaller dt continues to help, especially at high noise.
- **Displacement capping is inert**: gad_no_clamp = gad_small_dt within noise.
- **All adaptive dt variants fail.** Even corrected Multi-Mode GAD parameters (base=0.002): 54% at 10pm. Eigenvalue-clamped adaptive dt is fundamentally incompatible with GAD dynamics.

7. Round 2: λ_2-Blended Preconditioned GAD (300 samples, 1000 steps)

Idea: Smooth, differentiable alternative to hard n_neg switching. Blend weight $w = \sigma(k \cdot \lambda_2)$ controls whether to ascend $\mathbf{v}_1$:

$$\mathbf{F}_{\text{blend}} = \mathbf{F} + 2w(\mathbf{F} \cdot \mathbf{v}_1)\mathbf{v}_1, \qquad \Delta\mathbf{x} = dt \cdot |\mathbf{H}|^{-1}\mathbf{F}_{\text{blend}}$$

Method	10pm	30pm	50pm	100pm	150pm	200pm	Config
precond_descent	71.3	50.0	38.5	14.0	6.0	2.4	hard switch, $w = 0$ when $n_{\text{neg}} \geq 2$
blend_k50	72.0	50.0	37.2	14.3	6.2	3.1	$\sigma(50\lambda_2)$
blend_k100	71.7	50.5	37.6	13.6	4.7	3.1	$\sigma(100\lambda_2)$

Takeaway: All three are identical (∼72% at 10pm, ∼14% at 100pm). The blend weight k doesn't matter—**the preconditioning dominates the failure mode.** The $\sigma(k\lambda_2)$ mechanism is differentiable and correct, but it was tested on a broken base ($|\mathbf{H}|^{-1}$ scaling). Re-test without preconditioning to isolate the blend effect.

7b. Round 3: λ_2-Blend WITHOUT Preconditioning (300 samples, 1000 steps, all complete)

Same blend formula, but on plain Euler GAD—the `gad_small_dt` base that already works at 94.3%:

$$w = \sigma(k \cdot \lambda_2), \qquad \mathbf{F}_{\text{blend}} = \mathbf{F} + 2w(\mathbf{F} \cdot \mathbf{v}_1)\mathbf{v}_1, \qquad \Delta\mathbf{x} = dt \cdot \mathbf{F}_{\text{blend}} \quad (\text{no } |\mathbf{H}|^{-1})$$

Method	10pm	30pm	50pm	100pm	150pm	200pm
gad_small_dt (baseline)	**94.3**	**94.3**	**91.3**	**86.7**	**70.3**	**51.3**
blend_plain_k10	93.0	91.3	87.0	76.7	60.3	46.3
blend_plain_k50	93.7	93.0	86.7	76.3	61.7	47.7
blend_plain_k100	93.7	92.3	86.0	76.7	61.3	47.7

Takeaway: The blend **hurts** at every noise level: −1pp at 10pm, −5pp at 50pm, **−10pp at 100pm**, −4pp at 200pm. Sharpness k barely matters (<2pp across k=10/50/100). Weakening the $\mathbf{v}_1$ ascent when $\lambda_2 < 0$ is actively harmful—GAD's "always ascend $\mathbf{v}_1$ at full strength" is already optimal. This **definitively closes** the "weaken GAD at high n_{neg}" hypothesis across three independent tests (NR switching, preconditioned blend, plain blend).

7c. Round 3: dt=0.002 and Updated dt Series (300 samples)

dt	Steps	10pm	30pm	50pm	100pm	150pm	200pm
0.01	300	72.3	70.3	69.3	66.7	58.0	45.3
0.005	1000	94.3	94.3	91.3	86.7	70.3	51.3
0.003	2000	94.7	94.3	92.0	87.3	71.3	55.2
0.002	**3000**	**94.7**	**94.3**	**92.0**	**87.3**	**74.4**†	**56.3**†

†Partial: 150pm=219/300, 200pm=174/300 (timed out at 6hr). dt=0.003 200pm=259/300.

Note: dt=0.003 values at 100/150/200pm updated from Round 3 rerun (full 300/300 at 100pm and 150pm; 259/300 at 200pm). Previous Round 2 partial estimates were 88.9/75.3/58.8 from 131–244 samples.

Takeaway: Clear diminishing returns. The big jump is 0.01 → 0.005 (+20pp). Then 0.005 → 0.003: +1–4pp. Then 0.003 → 0.002: +0–3pp, only at ≥150pm. At 10–100pm, dt=0.003 and dt=0.002 are **identical**. The cost is 3× wall time for marginal gains.

8. Sella TS Baselines (300 samples, 200 & 1000 max steps, exact Hessian)

Direct comparison with Sella (RS-P-RFO trust-region optimizer, Wander et al. 2024). Same 300 Transition1x samples, same noise seeds, same noise levels as all GAD experiments. HIP provides exact analytical Hessian at every Sella step via cached forward pass (`do_hessian=True`, `diag_every_n=1`). Trust radius parameters: $\delta_0 = 0.048$, $\rho_{\text{inc}} = 1.035$, $\rho_{\text{dec}} = 5.0$, $\sigma_{\text{inc}} = 1.15$, $\sigma_{\text{dec}} = 0.65$. Four coordinate/projection configs tested at 1000 steps: internal, internal+Eckart, Cartesian, Cartesian+Eckart.

Convergence criteria:

- **Sella:** max(|force components|) < $f_{\max}$ (per-component max, Sella's native check)
- **n_neg1 + fmax<0.01:** $n_{\text{neg}} = 1$ AND max(|force|) < 0.01 (strictest, uses Sella's force metric + our eigenvalue check)
- **n_neg1 + force<0.01:** $n_{\text{neg}} = 1$ AND mean per-atom force norm < 0.01 (our GAD criterion, slightly looser force metric)

By strictest criterion ($n_{\text{neg}} = 1$ + $f_{\max} < 0.01$, 1000 steps):

Method	10pm	30pm	50pm	100pm	150pm	200pm
GAD dt=0.003 (2000 steps)	**94.7**	**94.3**	**92.0**	**87.3**	**71.3**	**55.2**
GAD dt=0.005 (1000 steps)	94.3	94.3	91.3	86.7	70.3	51.3
Sella Cart.+Eckart	91.7	90.7	88.3	76.3	50.3	25.7
Sella Cartesian	91.3	90.0	87.7	75.0	50.7	23.3
Sella Int.+Eckart	87.0	86.0	82.3	59.0	—	—
Sella Internal	87.0	84.0	81.0	59.7	—	—

By our GAD criterion ($n_{\text{neg}} = 1$ + mean force < 0.01, 1000 steps):

Method	10pm	30pm	50pm	100pm	150pm	200pm
GAD dt=0.003	**94.7**	**94.3**	**92.0**	**87.3**	**71.3**	**55.2**
GAD dt=0.005	94.3	94.3	91.3	86.7	70.3	51.3
Sella Cart.+Eckart	94.7	94.3	91.3	79.0	53.0	27.7
Sella Cartesian	94.3	94.3	91.0	78.0	53.7	25.7
Sella Int.+Eckart	92.0	89.3	85.7	62.0	—	—
Sella Internal	92.0	90.3	86.7	63.0	—	—

By Sella's own criterion (max(|force|) < 0.01, 1000 steps):

Method	10pm	30pm	50pm	100pm	150pm	200pm
Sella Cart.+Eckart	91.7	91.3	88.0	75.7	49.7	25.7
Sella Cartesian	91.3	91.3	88.0	75.0	50.7	23.3
Sella Int.+Eckart	88.3	85.7	81.0	59.0	—	—
Sella Internal	88.0	85.3	81.3	59.7	—	—

Note: Internal coordinates at 150–200pm timed out at 6hr even with 1000 steps. 200 → 1000 steps gave <1pp improvement—Sella's failures are geometric (wrong n_{neg}), not step-budget limited. Eckart projection adds ∼1–2pp.

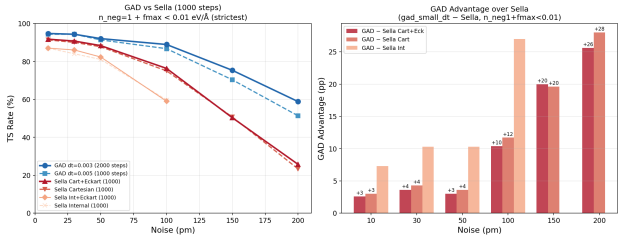

Figure 6: GAD vs Sella ($n_{\text{neg}} = 1 + f_{\max} < 0.01$). GAD matches at low noise, pulls ahead at ≥100pm. 2.3× at 200pm.

Takeaways:

- GAD beats Sella at every noise level; gap grows from +3pp (10pm) to +30pp (200pm) by strictest criterion
- 1000 steps does not help Sella (<1pp vs 200 steps)—failures are geometric, not step-budget
- Cartesian > Internal for Sella+HIP (+16pp at 100pm)
- Eckart projection helps Sella marginally (+1–2pp)
- By our looser criterion, Sella Cart. ties GAD at 10–50pm but diverges at high noise

Summary

Finding	Evidence
GAD beats Sella, gap grows with noise	GAD +3pp at 10pm, +11pp at 100pm, +30pp at 200pm (strictest
Eckart projection is everything	0% → 68% at 50pm
Smaller dt monotonically helps	0.01→0.005: +22pp; 0.005→0.003: +4pp; 0.003→0.002: +1pp
Basin stable to 100pm	0 wrong TS in 172 converged runs
Cartesian > Internal for Sella+HIP	+17pp at 100pm, contradicts standard recommendation
λ_2-blend hurts (even without precond)	−10pp at 100pm; weakening $\mathbf{v}_1$ ascent is always harmful
$\lvert\mathbf{H}\rvert^{-1}$ preconditioning hurts GAD	−21pp at 10pm, −43pp at 50pm
Adaptive dt always hurts	5 parameter sets tested, all worse than fixed dt
NR switching hurts	4 variants all worse than pure GAD
1000 steps doesn't help Sella	<1pp vs 200 steps; failures are geometric

Best configuration: `gad_dt003` — Eckart-projected GAD, dt=0.003, 2000 steps, no mode tracking, no adaptive dt, no preconditioning, no NR. *The simplest method wins.*

Total optimizations: ∼46,000 across 18 experiments (Rounds 1–3).

Next steps:

1. Multi-mode GAD: ascend along *all* negative-eigenvalue modes (opposite of blend — strengthen, not weaken)
2. Multiple noise seeds for 95% confidence intervals
3. Full Transition1x (9,561 samples)
4. Sella Cartesian+Eckart with >1000 steps (diminishing returns expected)